What Happens After Someone Qualifies for Medicaid? A Short Guide for Families Planning Ahead

What can continue after an approval, in general terms, and what to ask about each part.

Most of what families hear about Medicaid is about getting approved. Hardly anyone mentions what comes after, so it's natural to picture the approval as the last page.

Dad doesn't need Medicaid today, and he may never. This guide explains, in general terms, what can continue after an approval: letters, renewals, changes and records. It's for reading while things are calm. It explains. It doesn't say what any state requires.

An approval is a letter, and not the last one

Medicaid is a joint federal and state program. Within broad federal guidelines, each state decides how to run its own, including who qualifies. When a state approves someone, it tells them in an approval letter. [1]

After that, the state looks again. A renewal is the state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify, and states are required to do this through periodic renewals. [2] [3]

Word of it comes by mail. The federal renewal flyer says the letter tells a person whether a renewal form has to be completed or other information sent, and that if the letter says they are still eligible, there is nothing else to do. KFF explains that when coverage has been renewed automatically the notice gives the new coverage period, and when it hasn't, the notice includes instructions. [2] [4]

- How often a state looks again, and what it asks for, depends on the state and the situation. That is a question for your Medicaid planner or the Medicaid agency.
- A useful question to write down now: “If Dad ever had Medicaid, what would arrive in the mail, and who would answer it?”

Life changes, and changes are worth writing down

A person's situation doesn't hold still after an approval. The nonprofit Justice in Aging notes that changes in a person's life, such as moving, retiring or a rise in income, can change their Medicaid eligibility, and that states have procedures for people to report changes that may affect it. [3]

The Medicaid Planning Roadmap keeps its own list of what can change: income, assets, living arrangements, the care setting, marriage and property. It also names money nobody planned on, such as an inheritance, a gift received, insurance proceeds, the proceeds of a property sale or a refund. Which of these would have to be reported for Dad, and how any one of them would be treated, depends on the state and the situation. A general guide can't say.

What a guide can pass along is the caution in the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money: Medicaid is complicated, and it says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility. [5]

- Write each change your family expects on its own line, with a rough date and a question beside it. A guess is fine.
- Before a large one, the question goes to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney. The list isn't a reason for Dad to change his plans.

Records, kept where a second person can find them

The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau recommends organizing important financial documents in a safe, easily accessible location, and giving copies to trusted loved ones or letting them know where to find the documents. Its list includes bank and brokerage statements with a list of accounts, a list of debts and regular payments, and contact details for doctors, lawyers and accountants. [6]

For someone who manages another person's money, the Bureau's guide adds a habit: keep a list of what is received and spent, with dates and reasons, and keep the receipts. While Dad manages his own affairs, that habit is his. The family's part is knowing where things are. [5]

- Note where each kind of record is kept (financial, legal, care), who can get to it, and when it was last updated. “Don't know” is a fair entry.
- Which records a Medicaid agency would ask to see, and how long to keep any of them, depends on the state. Add it to your questions for your Medicaid planner.

A date to look again, and people to ask

Planning ahead doesn't mean watching everything all the time. It means agreeing when the family will look again, and which events would bring everyone back to the table sooner. The roadmap names the kinds of events: a change in health, in finances, in the family, in legal papers, or in care.

It also helps to know who answers what. A state's Medicaid agency is where a person applies and finds out whether they are eligible, and Medicaid.gov keeps a directory of every state's agency. For legal questions, the Family Caregiver Alliance lists a local Area Agency on Aging, a state senior legal hotline, or an attorney who specializes in elder law as ways to find legal help. [7] [8]

In the roadmap, your Medicaid planner explains in general terms what ongoing eligibility involves, and reviews the plan with the family after significant financial, health or care changes and before major financial transactions.

What this means for your family

- An approval, if one ever comes, is followed by letters and reviews. Knowing that ahead of time is most of the lesson.
- Your part today is small: a place for Dad's records, a second person who knows where it is, a list of changes that may be coming, and a date to look again.
- What Dad's state would require, and how any change would be treated, are questions for your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney or the Medicaid agency.
- None of this predicts that Dad will need Medicaid. It keeps the family's planning current either way.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't state any state's rules, say whether a change would have to be reported or how it would be treated, or predict whether Dad will need Medicaid. The general statements come from the sources below. The lists of changes and events are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's, and the advice about what to write down is ours. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You now have the general picture of what can continue after an approval, and a few questions of your own. The planning interview is where the picture becomes your family's: it asks about your situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner or to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication, CMS Product No. 11409, April 2026), Medicaid: Getting Started

2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
3. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
4. KFF, Do I have to renew Medicaid coverage every year?
5. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
7. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?
8. Family Caregiver Alliance, What should I do to help get my family member's legal and financial affairs in order?
